

POCO Pods

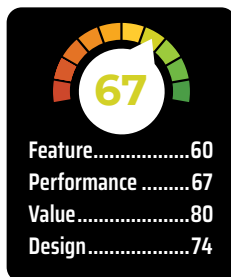
Delivering a decent quality TWS experience on a tight budget

With the increased competition in the consumer electronics space, manufacturers across categories are scrambling to get a piece of the market share in whatever way they can. We have seen sister companies share design and product ideas with each other, often coming out with products that are essentially the same but carry a different brand name. At the Digit Test Centre in Mumbai, we have had two such products very recently. Out of the two, one landed in a category that I work on. These were the POCO Pods.

POCO launched their TWS earbuds with a lot of hype. But when they turned up at the Digit Test Centre, I found out that they were essentially the Redmi Buds 4 Active, with a few tweaks made to the case. Essentially a change of shape. Having already put the Redmi Buds 4 Active through their paces when I was reviewing them, I was curious to see what lay in the case of the POCO Pods. And the findings were... Not surprising at all. Here's what I found out after testing the POCO Pods –

BUILD AND DESIGN

In terms of the design, my thoughts were somewhat the same as with the Redmi Buds 4 Active. The case of the POCO Pods has a dual-tone colour scheme, but it is a bit more aggressive here. The case, which has a sturdy hinge which can be used to pull off a party trick (read my other review to find out), and good quality materials used in its construction, especially for the price, has a black-coloured outer shell with a yellow inside cavity. The branding is a bit more aggressive on these earbuds,



with POCO's logo making its appearance on the front of the case in yellow colour.

The shape is where we see the biggest change from the Redmi Buds. While Redmi's offering had a shape leaning towards oval, the shape of the POCO Pods is much more circular.

Around the circumference of the case, we see the same with the POCO Pods. Moving to the earbuds,

The buds are a 1:1 remake of the Redmi Buds 4 Active. In my review of the Buds 4 Active, they are comfortable to wear for longer periods of time. I loved their fit, and being a fan of the stem-shaped design of the earbuds, I loved the way these earbuds sit in my ears. Even during my runs in the Mumbai heat, the buds held up against the light sweat, thanks to their IPX4 rating.

FEATURES

Much like the Redmi Buds 4 Active, the POCO Pods come with a concise yet robust set of features. While there

isn't an extensive array of features with these earbuds, what's included holds its ground quite well. Now, why didn't I conclude the sentence with "solid"? Well, that will become clear soon.

First off, let's talk about the positives. And the highlight here is the pairing process. Getting these earbuds into pairing mode is a breeze. Admittedly, it's not the most intuitive – you need to take the earbuds out of the case, put them in your ears, and give each of the stems three taps. But once they're in pairing mode, the process is reliable. The fast pairing feature with compatible devices also works like a charm. I've had experiences with more expensive earbuds boasting Google Fast Pair, but I must say, the Redmi Buds 4 Active hold their own in this department.

Now, let's come to the part I most gripe about - the controls. The control scheme of these earbuds is the one area where I expected Xiaomi to put in some extra elbow grease and refine things. It's a hit-and-miss situation, particularly when it comes to changing tracks. The responsiveness leaves something to be desired, and it's an area I hope the brand improves either in its next version or through a firmware update. Notably, the lack of volume control on the earbuds is another downside, causing them to lose a point in my book. Granted, such a feature isn't common in this price range, but I'd gladly pay an extra ₹250 to ₹500 for better controls and a couple more features. It's a missed opportunity, for sure. As it stands, the control limitations are a dealbreaker for me, personally. Take note.

In terms of the app, there's not much to elaborate on. You'll find a battery indicator and a toggle switch to turn the low latency mode on and off. Limited, but useful. These earbuds also come with Environmental Noise Cancellation (ENC) for listening. This nifty feature utilises software algorithms to pick up on any unusual sounds in your environment and counteract them. Given the price point these earbuds are retailing, this addition is a pleasant surprise. The results can be